

Week 8: Design Patterns in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Bible stories separated by centuries often share a shape on purpose. Tonight we follow one of those shapes — who gets to be "firstborn" — from Genesis to Jesus, and practice spotting the moves the authors use to tie stories together.

1. Have you ever noticed a movie or show deliberately echo an earlier scene — the same shot, the same line, the same choice — to make a point by comparison? What did that repetition make you think or feel?
2. The video traced one pattern — *see it, want it, take it* — from Eve through Aaron's golden calf to David. Every one of those stories is someone **grabbing** something that wasn't given to them. Where do you see that same grab — for status, recognition, control, being first — in your own life or in the people around you?
3. **Read Deuteronomy 21:15-17.** In that world, what did being the **firstborn son** actually get you? Why would a first-time reader expect God to back the firstborn every time?
4. **Read Genesis 4:1-8, Genesis 21:8-13, and Genesis 25:19-34.** Three brothers' stories, set close together at the front of the Bible. What keeps happening? Then look at Genesis 25:23, where the narrator says the quiet part out loud. What tips you off that this is the author's design and not just how things happened to fall?
5. **Read Genesis 48:8-20.** Jacob — who spent his youth stealing his older brother's blessing — is now old, and he deliberately crosses his hands to put the younger grandson, Ephraim, ahead of Manasseh. What changes about a pattern when a character seems to know he's standing inside it? (Glance at Genesis 49:3-4: Reuben, the actual firstborn, loses the birthright outright.)
6. **Read 1 Samuel 16:1-13.** Centuries after Genesis, the same shape: the youngest of eight, not even called in from the sheep. Verse 7 states the theme directly. Here's

the hard question for this whole way of reading: how do you tell a pattern the author *built* from one a reader is *imposing*? What in these texts settles it?

7. The younger brother who gets chosen rarely comes out clean — Jacob deceives, Joseph flaunts the dream, the brothers sell him off. Almost every war and rivalry in the Bible is framed as a fight between brothers; trace the genealogies and the whole cast turns out to be one feuding family. What is the pattern saying about people — not just firstborns, but everyone?
8. **Read Colossians 1:15-20 and Philippians 2:5-11.** Jesus' followers call him "the firstborn of all creation" — the ultimate birthright — and in the same breath say he "did not consider equality with God something to be grasped," but emptied himself. How does Jesus both **complete** this pattern and **break** it?
9. **Read Luke 15:11-32.** Jesus takes the oldest pattern in the book — a younger son, an older son, a blessing between them — and gives it a new ending. Who is each brother meant to be? And what is the father doing that no one in Genesis ever did?
10. Knowing how deliberately these patterns were woven across dozens of books and centuries, how does that shape the way you think about the Bible?